

film reviews

Feel-good and Fun

JAB WE MET

Director: Imtiaz Ali

Starring: Shahid Kapur, Kareena Kapoor

Director Imtiaz Ali is a master of the small moments. So *Jab We Met* (JWM), easily the most charming rom-com of the year, is full of witty asides and characters. Like the heroine's wannabe fiancé who tries to impress her with a career in fertilisers; or the man behind the counter at a seedy hotel in Ratlam who mistakes the couple for a prostitute and client; or the curmudgeonly grandfather (a perfectly cast Dara Singh), who insists that at his age, a man can recognise love in a minute.

Of course, Ali, who also wrote the story,



Kareena and Shahid

screenplay and dialogue, airbrushes reality but unlike many Bollywood romances, JWM never feels synthetic. The story of two strangers on a train, who fall in love, hums along nicely despite an unnecessarily convoluted second half.

The actors are in full

throttle. Shahid Kapur's nicely underplayed performance is the perfect foil for Kareena Kapoor's Sikhini from Bhatinda, who is so animated that she even talks in her sleep. JWM is witty and feel-good, but it won't give you a sugar rush. Watch it.

by Anupama Chopra



Noir Goes Nuts

NO SMOKING

Director: Anurag Kashyap
Starring: John Abraham, Ranvir Shorey

John Abraham's character called K, simply K, stands bare-chested in front of the mirror, making a Travis Bickle kind of statement, a cigarette be-

Gone up in smoke

tween his lips: No one tells me what to do. Unfortunately, Abraham is no Robert de Niro and Kashyap is not Martin Scorsese. The film is an incoherent mass of inside jokes (scriptwriter Abbas Tyrewala being the unhappy recipient of the barbs), silly references (Paresh Rawal's babaji is

bewilderingly shown to be Hitler's compatriot) and meaningless snapshots of Mumbai (beautifully photographed though by Rajeev Ravi). K doesn't want to give up smoking, his wife Anjali wants him to. There is a deeper existential crisis the film is alluding to, in the manner of Franz Kafka's *The Trial*, but even a patient and generous viewing cannot help deconstruct it. The only time anyone smiles is when the opening credits, bearing quotes from Plato, Socrates and then Frank Sinatra come up. Precious and pretentious. Kashyap is a talented filmmaker but the yearning to be taken seriously is the death of entertainment. Noir is fine, nonsense isn't.

by Kaveree Bamzai

recommendations

Nature Divine



A photo by Datta

KOLKATA Widely acclaimed landscape photographer, Soumitra Datta, has been practising this art for over two decades. His latest exhibition, edited by photographer Raghu Rai, manages to make scenic beauty seem like an impressionist painting. "To endeavour to capture this transient beauty also means supporting the cause of nature's conservation," he says. At the Academy of Fine Arts, November 4 to 11.

by Swagata Sen



The Mega Laxmi

DELHI Himanshu Varma is celebrating Diwali in a much more creative way this time with his Festival of Lights from November 5 to 10 at Alliance Francaise. With the help of 12 artists, a large variety of lights—candles, diyas, disco lights, neon lights and fluorescent lights—will be used to ignite the festival's spirit. To add to the heat, serigraphy artist Arjuna will be displaying his latest work, the new Mahalakshmi *The Mega Laxmi*, along with other paintings depicting the deities of modern India.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit